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THE VOICE EXPRESS

The Truth Takes Time.

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FROM THE EDITORS Welcome to the September 2024 edition of Voice Express. Our correspondents bring you the stories that matter — from frontlines of policy to quiet revolutions in culture and science.

POLITICS

Jai Bhim Kunj

On two kinds of hijacking — the demolition of Jai Bhim Nagar in Mumbai's Hiranandani complex, and the suppression of Dalit and working-class voices within Delhi's 'apolitical' Reclaim the Night protests. An editorial on who gets to own a movement's grief, and what solidarity means when it is curated.

BY MOULI SHARMA



How Hiranandani and Jai Bhim Nagar's Case is Quietly Mirrored in the 'Apolitical Reclaim the Night's of Gentrified New Delhi, & There is More Than One Way to Hijack a Protest

19th August 2024: There's a poem by Amrita Pritam called 'Hear-Say' that goes a little something like this: there's a game of two chits - one of them reads 'Hear' and the other reads, 'Say'. Every round, He and She take their picks, and do as their chits demand. Every round, by fate or coincidence, She picks, 'Hear', and does as she is told. The King tells her, 'Drink poison'. Meera becomes She. The Saint tells her, 'Turn to stone'. Ahalya becomes She. The Lord tells her, 'Get out'. Sita becomes She. Through pyres, she cannot scream. Through divorce, she grits her teeth. The chit that reads 'Hear' never does land His way.

The first time I heard this poem was three days ago on the footpath outside Vasant Square Mall on the 16th night of August 2024, in the voice of a child not a day older than 14, protesting rape.
And so it was.

Despite being held at Vasant Square Mall, an affluent locality of Vasant Kunj Sector-B, the demonstration had been organized – purposefully and significantly – by the local domestic workers' union: SGU (Sangrami Gharelu Kamgaar Union), Collective Delhi, and residents of the Harijan Basti the same distance from the mall as the upper-class B2 gated-community.

The palpably apolitical nature of the protest despite its organisation by a political group is noteworthy, not least because the residents of the Harijan Basti and B2 Residents' Welfare Association have a history of conflict rich enough to rival Powai. In light of the recent media attention garnered by the vocal and insulting exclusion of Jai Bhim Nagar ex-residents by Hiranandani residents at what they proclaimed was exclusively their 'reclaim the night' protest, there has formed conspicuous and necessary room in the nationwide antirape sentiment gaining steam right now for an acknowledgment that caste-based violence – just like sexual violence – does not emerge from vacuum. Both grow progressively, & passively, in environments that foster prejudice, microaggressions, and systemic dehumanisation; the languages and cultures of hegemony – all of which were enthusiastically present at the gathering on 16th August, 2024. If only one were willing to look.

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Jai Bhim Kunj • CONTINUED
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8:15 | Kalpana

The WhatsApp forward circulated the same morning states that the protest starts at 8:30 PM outside Vasant Square Mall. By 8:15, people begin to arrive. Many wander into the fire assembly area in front of the mall building, wondering where everyone’s supposed to meet. They don’t know that the protest isn’t meant to happen up there in front of the kiddie rides and KFC, but down on the road, where everyone can see.



(WhatsApp circulated poster, via SGU)

Com. Shreya, a seasoned activist and the anchor of this protest, runs back and forth between the two places, waiting for wanderers at the stairs of the mall, nudging them in the right direction. Shreya doesn’t think there was any (noteworthy) classism at the protest. The many times I ask Shreya for the contacts of the union members themselves, she’s also sure to tell me that they didn’t either.

“Are you from the Union?” She asks. I tell her I’m not from the neighborhood. Her friend wanders away. When asked who’s organising the event, she simply says, “ the library” expecting me to figure the rest out myself. When I don’t, she throws me more hints: the Harijan Basti, the Union, B2 . I think of John Mulaney’s set on why thirteen-year-olds are the most terrifying people on earth.

A nearby adult notices my confusion and clarifies that she’s talking about the local domestic workers union, namely the Sangrami Gharelu Kamgaar Union (SGU), who gave the call for the meeting, and then begins teasing Kalpana about her awaited poetry recitation. The kid is unbothered, nonchalant like she could do it blindfolded. “I won’t even need to look at it once.”

In the end, she reads the whole thing off a phone. ‘Hear-Say’ by Amrita Pritam, rushed and unintonated like only an eighth grader can manage. She doesn’t bother sticking around for praise.



(Photograph via Collective, by Akshay)

8:30 | Class Clown

By 8:30, the crowd in front of VSM organise themselves the way members of any civil society will do without external interference: into cliques. Looking up at them from the elevated rails of the mall, they look a bit the way oil does over water. Bound clusters with space in between.

A few minutes ago, these groups didn’t exist. It’s natural to fall into them once they form; every time new participants arrive, typically with a few members of the family, they scan the crowd for people they recognise, and assimilate. But fifteen minutes ago there weren’t enough heads around for one to even look for familiar faces. Fifteen minutes ago, everyone was a straggler.

On the other side is the much larger group of mostly Bengali women with their heads covered with aanchals or dupattas to pair with their salwar-kameez (except one who shows up in a nightie. She jokes about it (‘I just came here in a nightie.’) but no one laughs, and it becomes clear that these women aren’t just neighbors but friends). The activists are attached to this group, but they keep themselves busy with pleasantries and inventory. Scattered between the two are the true stragglers: a young man nursing the straps of his backpack. An antisocial doctor who doesn’t know what to do with herself. A journalist lugging around a camera that’s dead.

Soon, it’s decided that sufficient people have shown up to begin. Shreya joins us from her designated position at the base of the stairs and takes charge. Her directions are clear and unambiguous, and the team works fast. Candles and posters are distributed to those who haven’t brought them, and people are asked to arrange themselves in a semicircle formation – SGU members in the front row. Beside me, Nightie Lady jokes that she can’t be expected to hold her candle and her poster at the same time (something something flammable materials, something something all the work around this house). When she sees me smile, she holds the paper against her stomach as if trying to fix it there (it reads, “Fight on, RG Kar! We are with you!”) and raises her eyebrows. I wonder if the four upper-class women still standing at the very front of the formation are going to move. They aren’t.

I raise my eyebrows back.

9:00 | Anita



(Shreya addressing the gathering, via SGU by Gowri)

She says it with a smile, like there’s a joke in there I’m not in on. I am in on it, though. The oil spill had cross-contamination. I’d seen one of the women from the RWA group walk over and extricate one of the SGU members to bring her back into hers and introduce her to everyone. An ex-employee. ‘ Do you recognise Didi? She took care of you when you were this small. ’ A servant.

Shreya goes on about the order of the night. SGU women will share their views, and then so will anyone else who wishes to. I curse myself for not checking the battery on my camera before leaving the house and ask one of the activists named Gowri - who offered me one a few minutes ago - if I could have that candle anyway.



(Candleholders, Photograph via SGU by Gowri)

“Women should have the right to prove themselves. But having to prove themselves over and over, again and again – they die before they get to stop. Today, this has happened to a doctor. She worked 12-14 hours a day & for what? Just to save lives, yet her own life was put to an end.” The man with the backpack is puttering around behind me trying to find a candle that stays alight. I steal one from him and blend back into the crowd.

As Anita begins to wrap up – having given the discourse an edge by immediately establishing that women’s ‘liberation’ today is nominal & localised to urban areas – she stresses the importance of women standing together, pointing out how often it is that even within feminine – if not feminist – circles, the burden of proof is placed upon victims. Just as she starts to move the conversation toward a dialogue on internalised misogyny and victim shaming, though, one of the upper-class women in the front row begins applauding her. “Very good.” She says, approvingly. “Very good, yes, women should support women.”

Anita pauses for a beat, then recovers, again beginning to complete her thought. But the old woman interrupts again, concluding her sentence for her, and punctuating the end of the speech with more clapping. The crowd joins in with finality, and Anita returns to her place. Two women beside me begin whispering in Bengali, asking each other how long they plan on staying. “I’m going to leave in five minutes,” says one.

The other replies, “Me too.”



(Com. Anita, Photograph by Mouli Sharma)

9:30 | Rehaya

“The water supply pump to the basti goes under the B2 block at Vasant Kunj. Some defect in the pipe had led to extremely bad quality water being supplied. Members of RWA in B2 are preventing the pipes from being fixed. The reason? The machine will spoil the grass in the newly constructed park. Aesthetics of the few over basic human needs of the masses. Protests are ongoing (sic)” - 8th August 2024, Facebook, Sangrami Gharelu Kamgaar Union .

So it is unsurprising that as the conversations begin to drag on, and as the sans-mic stage is slowly and quietly wrestled away from the protesters that initiated, organised, and made up the majority of the protest to those that prevented it from happening in front of my eyes, that the tension gets stronger.

The speeches begin to meld together, and the testimonies turn into rants. A woman from the RWA group turns to the circle and implores all women to hold men accountable at all stages of violence, directly addressing the domestic workers.

“Rape is not the first thing a rapist does,” she says, repeating a rhetoric that’s already been made several times over by several different women in several different speeches that have said the same thing. “You have to stop them at the first step. When someone touches you in the bus, publicly shame him! I have done it. I did when I was in my 20s! It discourages them from doing more.” A few more women shuffle off from the Union side. They have work tomorrow.

The advice turns into an argument within the RWA group as the speech is followed by another that reiterates, yet again, that the responsibility is not all ours. I wonder if the conversation has moved forward a single step from where Anita’s speech left off, and don’t bother wondering too hard. I stop recording the speeches and start taking notes on who speaks and for how long. A total of 15 speeches are delivered by the end of the hour, not counting cross-conversation – only four by domestic workers, and not one of them uninterrupted.

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Two women beside me are having a sidebar, one of whom is named Rehaya. As yet another RWA woman goes on about shaming Eve teasers as a rape-preventing strategy, I join in. From the centre of the semicircle, a domestic worker who has been vocal from the start shares an incident where she and her family beat up a guy harassing their daughter on their street. “Ma’am, this happened to us once. We beat him up, we beat him up good,” she says. “Very good, you did well.” The RWA members approve.

Rehaya, personally, does not share my derision - of course, according to Shreya & Arundhati, neither do the majority of the union or its activists - or that of the women around who are planning their escapes. Her only contention is that for all the talk of all women standing for all others, all women hardly stand against all men.

“These boys are also someone’s sons, aren’t they? When their sons do something, do they support the girl? Of course not, they don’t even believe her. They think their sons can do no wrong.” Someone from the other end says that violence isn’t the answer.

And so it goes.

9:45 | Dispersal

Another 15 minutes of talking later, Shreya asks us all to hold hands and form a chain. The clusters appear again, divided cleanly by Kho-Kho poles of people holding posters standing in between, such that no one has to touch anyone they don’t want to. A few days later when I tell Shreya about this story to try to score some interviews she is less than elated. She shares with me her apprehensions about comparing a comfortable inter-class protest with an incident as ‘extreme’ as Hiranandani’s, which are understandable. I explain to her that the comparison is not one of degree, but of foundation, which helps but does not satisfy her. She defends the B2 residents with all her might. “They were only speaking because we asked them to speak. What happened here was completely different. Some of the B2 women even held hands with their maids,” She says, like it helps her case. “The women were really happy.”

What I remember, though, is that Rehaya didn’t mind holding mine. Even with all my sweating.



(Photographs via Collective, by Akshay)

The candles and posters were left in the middle, like some kind of remembrance. Facing the road repeating slogans after Shreya alongside 50 other women, I felt sad how loud I could hear the sound of my own voice.

I wish I could tell you the night was the triumph it was made out to be. I wish I could write the article Shreya & Anubhuti would want me to. Class and caste uniting for women; an intersectional battle against patriarchy & sexual violence. But it wasn’t.

Everytime a woman from the union tried to bring up – & doesn’t it sound like a dirty, dirty word – politics of any kind, she was shut down by someone from the RWA explaining to her how this was not the place, or the time. “It’s not about her being a doctor,” a woman from my side of the semicircle had begun after a neighbourhood doctor had come over to personally announce the national IMA strike, only to be unceremoniously cut off by the old woman from earlier, saying, “but you have to consider what happened afterwards, you have to consider what they did to her,” and so it went.

In the end, the night was left unclaimed. By ten o’clock everyone had made nice and left, leaving a mess of wax and paper behind. No Shelter for Sandip Ghosh. End Rape Culture. Freedom from Patriarchy. Rise Above Caste and Communal Violence. Safety for ALL Working Women. A little pile of white and black in the middle of the sidewalk. The chit that read ‘Say’ was lost among them.

The auto driver had asked me what that pile was when the crowd in front of it had gone. “It was for a protest against what happened in Kolkata,” I told him. “Oh,” was all he said back, and as we left, I thought of whoever next morning would have to sweep it all away.

I was glad it wasn’t me.



(Photograph via SGU, by Anandita)



(Photographs via Collective, by Akshay)

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